

PARTING GIFT

Upgrade

The Blueprint

At the goodbye party they get emotional, admitting they're scared of retiring — they don't know how they'll fill the time. You and the others promise to keep in touch. That closeness pays off: a couple of years later, over coffee, they hand you a blueprint for an upgrade to the machine, worked out in their spare...

Gain one machine upgrade for free (you still need the required professions for an Amplifier step).

PARTING GIFT

Boon

The Honey Trap

They leave with no more than 'it's been great, I wish you luck,' and toddle off. Their coldness nags at you, so you have an engineer check the outbox — and find they'd been blackmailed into feeding intelligence to a rival lab. You spring a honey trap down the channel they conveniently left open, feed it misinformation,...

Recruit any one available researcher at half the normal Cash cost (round down).

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Reputation

The Lecture Circuit

They get a wonderful send-off and soon begin giving talks at universities around the world. They are gracious, and they always mention where they did their best work. Questions about their time on your team come up often, and your name travels with theirs.

Gain 2 Reputation.

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Protégé

The Protégé

They seem a little overwhelmed on their last day and come to you quietly. They've been moonlighting as a professor, they confess, and they've met a postdoc — brilliant, a little raw — who they think would fit right in. They'd consider it a personal favour.

Recruit, for free, a junior Researcher of the same profession as the retiree (draw the top matching card; if none, the next junior).

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Boon

The Endowment

It turns out they'd quietly been putting their bonuses into the lab's name the whole time. The letter from the trust arrives a month after they leave, with a figure attached and a note that simply reads: 'Spend it on something reckless.'

Gain 6 Cash.

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Reputation

The Memoir

Retirement gives them the time to write the book they always threatened to. It is generous, indiscreet, and a bestseller in three countries. The chapter about your lab is the one everyone quotes.

Gain 3 Reputation.

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The Spare Key

On their way out they press a worn brass key into your hand — to the old workshop annex no one remembers renting. Inside is a lifetime of half-finished side projects, and one of them is exactly the part you've been missing.

On your next expedition only, draw +1 skill card into your opening hand.

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Boon

The Last Favour

They never were one for sentiment. 'You'll need a clean machine for whatever you're planning,' they say, already halfway out the door, and spend their final week stripping every trace of wear out of the Stabiliser housing.

Immediately remove all instability tokens from your machine (and the matching Trace cards from your skills deck).